

RAGHU DIXIT
 took Dixit nine years
 and four aborted
 record deals to launch
 his self-titled album
Raghu Dixit.
LAUNCH PAD Vishal
 and Shekhar Music
 and Counter
 Culture
 Records



AVIAL

The five-member group got together in 2003 to form India's first Malyalee rock band.

LAUNCH PAD Phat Phish

Records helped them to launch their album *Avial*.

JALEBEE CARTEL

The five-member electronic music band has gained popularity without releasing a single CD on an Indian label and by performing live all over the country.

LAUNCH PAD Their first Indian release will be on the independent label Mummy Daddy Records.



Hindi and Kannada with folk overtones. For the most part he had also been knocking on the doors of all big record companies. Most of them didn't listen to his music, while others wanted him to change his style to make it more saleable "and the ones who did listen wanted me to give them money for marketing and promotion", says Dixit. "Within five minutes of listening to Raghu we decided to start a label," says Shekhar.

There are many reasons why big companies don't touch small artistes. One, they expect instant returns. But small labels who "do this from the heart" as Vishal says, don't think of money in the short term. The second reason is that stringent contracts bind them to a stipulated period and give them only a tiny percentage of CD sales. "The payment to musicians doesn't include revenue from live acts and performances," explains Arjun Vagale of progressive electronic band Jalebee Cartel that has been releasing one track every month on an average on international labels such as Segment Records in England, SoulTribe Records in Germany and Existence Records in Canada. Jalebee recently tied up with an independent company, Mummy Daddy Records, launched by Amrish Kumar, son of veteran fashion designer Ritu Kumar, for an April launch in India.

"Unlike a big label, it's the artiste who holds the copyright with us," says Phat Phish's Anand Surapur, adding that his company gives the musicians the time and dedication that a big one can't. That is probably why Avial and Bengali rocker Mou stood by Phat Phish even when the company went through a two-year financial crunch. Also while the big guys work with sky-high overhead costs, independent labels do their job without frills. According to industry analysts, it can take anywhere between

SWEET NOTE: (Clockwise from front) Ash Roy, Arjun Vagale, Madhav, G-Force Arjun and Ashvin